

Civil Services (Main) Qualifying English - Paper B

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 300

Q1. Essay [100 marks]

Write about 600 words on any one topic.

1. Convenience without responsibility weakens citizenship.
2. Efficiency is not the same as effectiveness.
3. Certainty can be a barrier to learning.
4. Reading is an exercise in freedom.

Marking guidance: Marking rubric: relevance and qualified thesis 20; organisation 20; analysis, examples and balance 25; grammar and vocabulary 25; conclusion and approximate 600-word limit 10.

Q2. Comprehension [75 marks]

Public institutions often give greater attention to constructing a new asset than to maintaining an existing one. Construction creates a visible object and a date for inauguration; maintenance is repetitive, dispersed and difficult to celebrate. Yet the reliability of a road, school, irrigation channel or digital platform depends on regular inspection, repair and adaptation. Neglect rarely causes immediate collapse. A blocked drain, a small crack or an outdated software component first reduces the system's ability to absorb pressure. Under heavy rain, high demand or an emergency, minor weaknesses interact and create what appears to be a sudden failure. The problem is financial because capital and maintenance budgets are often separated. It is also institutional because responsibility may be divided among agencies, each expecting another to act. Users can supply early warnings, but their information matters only when complaints are acknowledged, assigned and followed by visible action. Good maintenance is therefore a form of public ethics: it respects money already spent, prevents avoidable harm and protects citizens who cannot purchase private alternatives.

1. Why does construction usually receive more public attention than maintenance?

Model answer: Construction is visible and offers an inauguration, whereas maintenance is repetitive, dispersed and less easily celebrated.

2. Why may a supposedly sudden failure actually be the result of long neglect?

Model answer: Small defects gradually reduce resilience and then interact under stress, producing a crisis whose causes accumulated over time.

3. Identify one financial and one institutional cause of poor maintenance.

Model answer: Financially, capital and maintenance budgets are separated; institutionally, fragmented responsibility allows each agency to wait for another.

4. When does information supplied by users become useful?

Model answer: It becomes useful when institutions acknowledge it, assign responsibility and report or undertake corrective action.

5. Suggest a title and state the central argument.

Model answer: A suitable title is 'The Ethics of Maintenance'. The passage argues that reliable maintenance is essential to efficiency, equity and accountable public service.

Q3. Precis Writing [75 marks]

Write a precis in about one-third of the passage. Do not give a title.

Modern life rewards speed. Messages travel instantly, goods arrive rapidly and public opinion forms before facts have been fully examined. Speed can save lives and reduce costs, so every delay is easily treated as incompetence. Yet valuable work often needs time for attention, verification and judgment. A doctor may need to act quickly, but an incomplete diagnosis can expose a patient to needless treatment. A judge should avoid unnecessary procedure, but a decision made without hearing the parties is not efficient justice. Digital interfaces intensify the conflict by shortening the distance between impulse and action. Institutions should therefore distinguish delay from deliberation. Delay occurs when work is unattended or procedure serves no

purpose; deliberation occurs when evidence is gathered, claims are compared and reasons are recorded. Measurement must also go beyond disposal counts, because workers may close cases without solving them when only speed is rewarded. Individuals need similar habits: verify before forwarding, pause before replying in anger and examine alternatives before an irreversible choice. The mature alternative to haste is not endless postponement but disciplined timeliness: acting as soon as necessary knowledge, authority and safeguards are present.

Model answer: Speed is valuable but cannot replace attention and judgment. In medicine, justice and digital action, haste may create serious errors. Institutions must separate idle delay from useful deliberation, which gathers evidence and records reasons. Performance measures should reward solved problems rather than rapid disposal. Individuals should also verify claims, control impulsive replies and consider alternatives. The proper goal is disciplined timeliness: action without needless delay once adequate knowledge and safeguards exist.

Q4. Usage and Vocabulary [50 marks]

A. Correct the sentences

1. One of the files are missing.

Answer: One of the files is missing.

2. She is capable to solve the problem.

Answer: She is capable of solving the problem.

3. The officer discussed about the proposal.

Answer: The officer discussed the proposal.

4. Neither of the alternatives are acceptable.

Answer: Neither of the alternatives is acceptable.

5. I have been waiting since three hours.

Answer: I have been waiting for three hours.

B. Supply the missing preposition or word

1. comply ____

Answer: with

2. abstain ____

Answer: from

3. responsible ____

Answer: for

4. distinguish X ____

Answer: from Y

5. insist ____

Answer: on

C. Use the correct verb form

1. By the time we arrived, the meeting ____ (end).

Answer: had ended

2. If she ____ (work) regularly, she will improve.

Answer: works

3. The officer ____ (read) when the call came.

Answer: was reading

4. The Earth ____ (move) around the Sun.

Answer: moves

5. He ____ (serve) here since 2022.

Answer: has served

D. Choose the correct word

1. complement/compliment

Answer: complement

2. stationary/stationery

Answer: stationery

3. principal/principle

Answer: principle

4. affect/effect

Answer: affect

5. discreet/discrete

Answer: discreet

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS